and annihilated by the advancing Japanese Army. On May 1, 1942, Mandalay fell. The escape of these Allied forces was essential for the defense of India. The only escape route for Allied troops and civilian refugees was a 600-mile trek through jungles, over rivers, and across mountain ranges. The exodus of troops and refugees was complicated by the fact that over 90 percent of the participants had contracted malaria.

The allied defeat in Burma was mainly due to the reliance on insufficient air and naval power combined with ill-equipped and poorly trained infantry units. Trucks and tanks left the allies dependent on roads, while the lightly armed Japanese took to the jungle, quickly outflanking and enveloping the allies. Profound disagreements over military strategy, including whether or not to defend Mandalay in Upper Burma or to counterattack Rangoon contributed to the loss of Burma.

THE STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE OF THE BURMA ROAD

The term “Burma Road” is actually a misnomer. In actuality, the Burma Road was a 1,154-kilometer supply route comprising a series of roads and trails built by the Allies and completed in 1939, linking Lashio, in eastern Burma, to Kunming in Yunnan province, China, to supply Chiang Kai-shek's nationalist troops. Both the Allies and the Japanese realized the strategic importance of the Burma Road. If the Allies were able to keep the road open they would be able to continue an overland supply route to the nationalist Chinese troops, thus enabling the Chinese to keep open a vital front against the Japanese. If the Japanese were to succeed in closing the Burma Road, they would force the Allies to fly supplies via northwest India over the Himalayas to continue to supplying the Chinese. Keeping the Burma Road open was not only important militarily, but also psychologically for the Allies. The IJA had swept through Southeast Asia conquering all in front of them. Reputations were won and lost as a series of Allied commanders came to terms with the Japanese and the dense Burmese jungles. Men such as Lieutenant General William Slim, General Joseph Stilwell, and General Orde Wingate would become household names in the United States and Great Britain for their exploits against the Japanese in the jungles of Burma.